PatchworkPDF

User Manual

Version 3.1

Written by Gareth Finch

2026

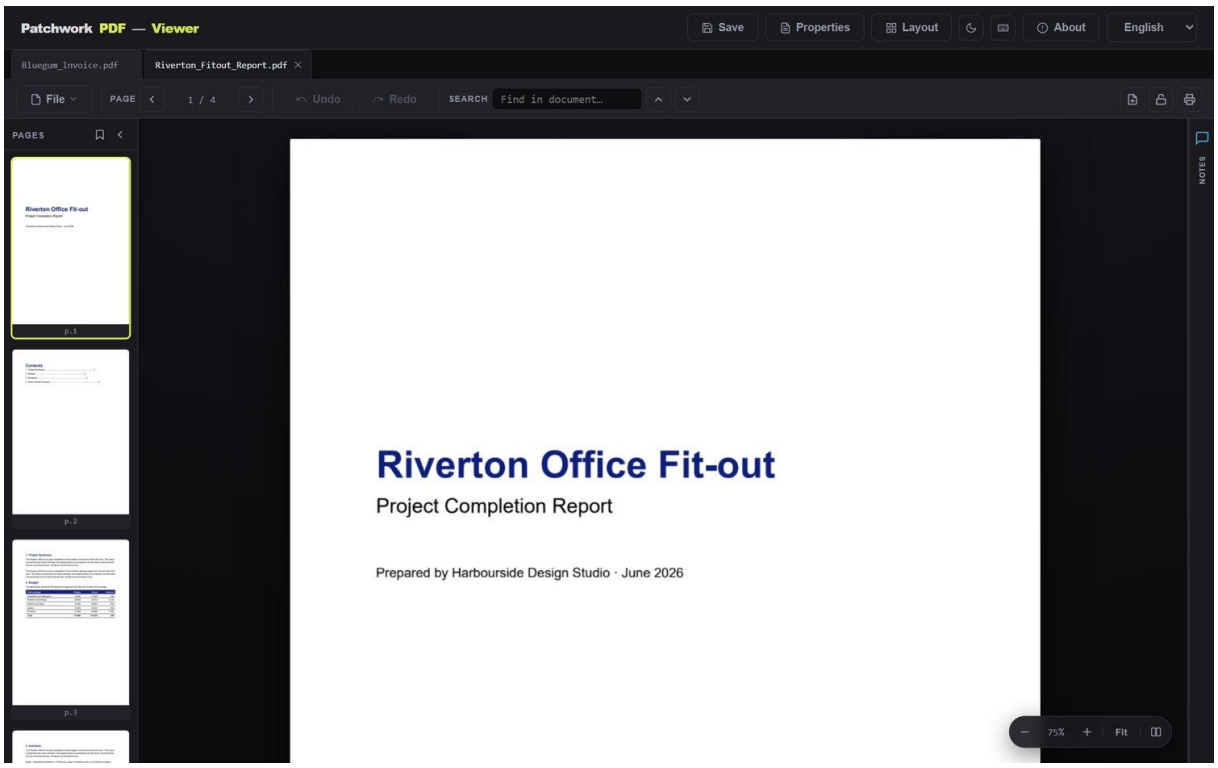


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(If the page numbers above are missing or out of date, right-click the table in Word and choose Update Field.)

Introduction

PatchworkPDF is a lightweight PDF tool that runs entirely on your own computer. There is no cloud, no account, and no upload to anyone else's servers — every document you open is processed locally on your machine.

With PatchworkPDF you can open, read, search and bookmark PDFs; fill in forms; combine and reorder pages from many files; annotate and comment; and change the page itself — edit its existing text, add new text, redact, watermark, crop and add form fields. It also converts Word, Excel, OpenDocument and text files to PDF as you open them, and exports PDFs back to Word and Excel.

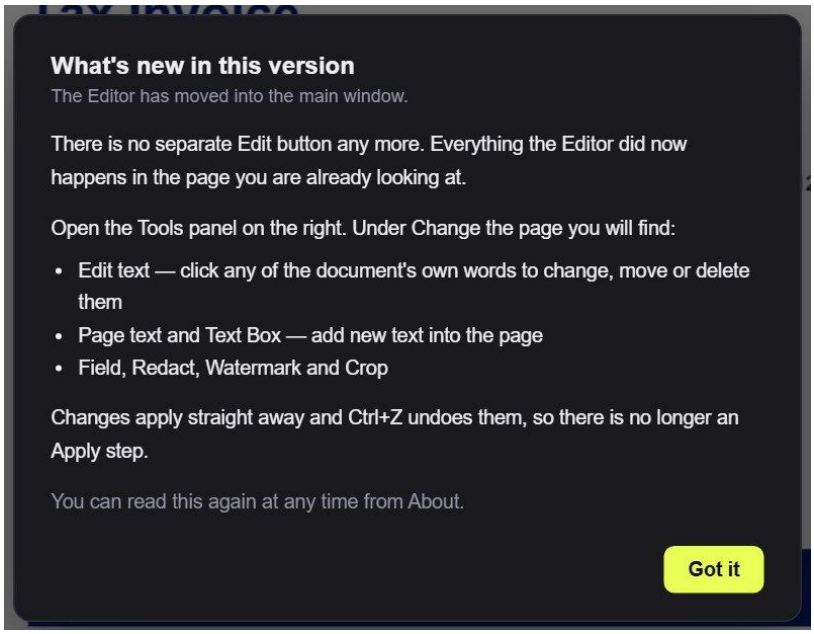
While a lot of effort has gone into the accuracy of edited text, scanned pages depend on how well OCR can read them, which limits how exact an edit on a scan can be (see section 3.9).

What's new in version 3.1

The separate Editor screen has been merged into the main window. Everything it did now happens on the page you are already looking at, from the **Tools** panel on the right-hand side:

- **Edit text** — click the document's own words to change, move or delete them, and **Row / area** editing for several words or lines at once.
- **Page text** and **Text Box** — add new text into the page.
- **Field**, **Redact**, **Watermark** and **Crop**.

There is no Apply step any more: every change is applied straight away and **Ctrl+Z** undoes it. The first time you start 3.1 a short "What's new" note explains this; you can read it again at any time from **About → What's New**.



The "What's new" note shown the first time you start version 3.1.

Installing OCR (Tesseract)

Scanned pages — and PDFs made with “Microsoft Print to PDF” and similar — contain pictures of text rather than text. To search, select or edit that text PatchworkPDF uses the free, open-source **Tesseract** OCR engine. Everything else in PatchworkPDF works without it.

Windows

- Run the Tesseract installer from the SourceForge page where you downloaded PatchworkPDF, and accept the default install location.

Linux

- Tesseract is bundled in the Flatpak — there is nothing extra to install.

macOS

1. Open a Terminal window.
2. Run **brew install tesseract**.

If you don’t already have Homebrew, see brew.sh for the one-line install.

> **NOTE** OCR language data for English, Spanish, French, German and Italian ships with PatchworkPDF. Text is read in the language you have chosen for the app, plus English.

Getting Started

The two screens

PatchworkPDF has two screens:

Viewer — the home screen. This is where the app starts and where you do almost everything: open documents, read, search, bookmark, fill in forms, print and save — and, from the **Tools** panel on the right, annotate the page and change its content. It is also your hub for working with several documents at once through tabs.

Layout — the page-assembly screen. Use Layout to work on the document as a whole: combine files, reorder, rotate, insert and delete pages, add headers and footers, compress the file, and export to Word or Excel.

> **NOTE** Earlier versions had a third screen, the Editor. In 3.1 its tools live in the Viewer's Tools panel (chapter 3), so there is no longer a separate Edit button.

Supported file types

You can open and combine the following formats. Anything that isn't a PDF is converted to PDF automatically as you open it:

- PDF (.pdf)
- Word (.doc, .docx)
- Excel (.xls, .xlsx)
- OpenDocument (.odt, .ods)
- Rich Text (.rtf), CSV (.csv) and plain text (.txt)

> **TIP** Word and Excel files convert best when Microsoft Office is installed. Without it PatchworkPDF uses LibreOffice if it can find it.

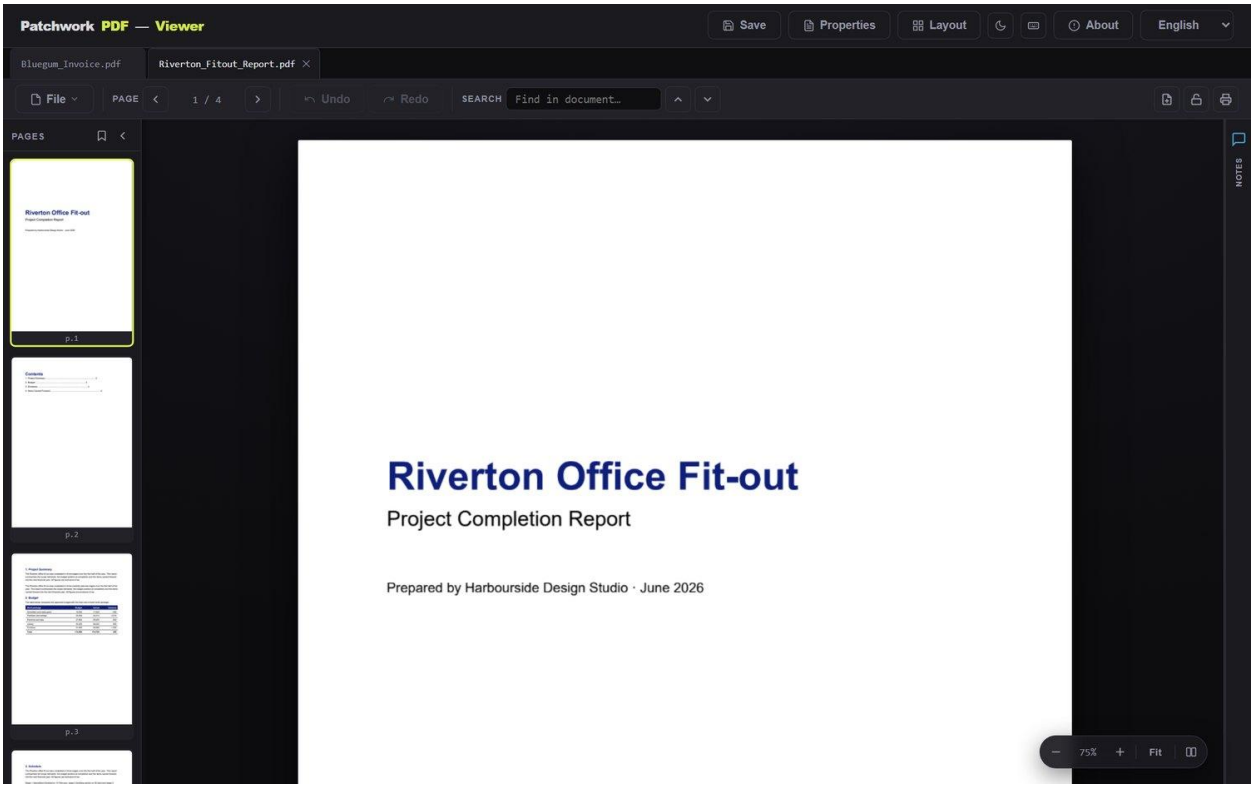
First start

The first time you run PatchworkPDF it shows the usage licence; click **I Accept** to continue. You can read the licence again at any time from **About**.

Only one copy of PatchworkPDF runs at a time. Opening another PDF — by double-clicking it in Explorer, for example — brings the running window to the front and opens the file in a new tab.

1. The Viewer

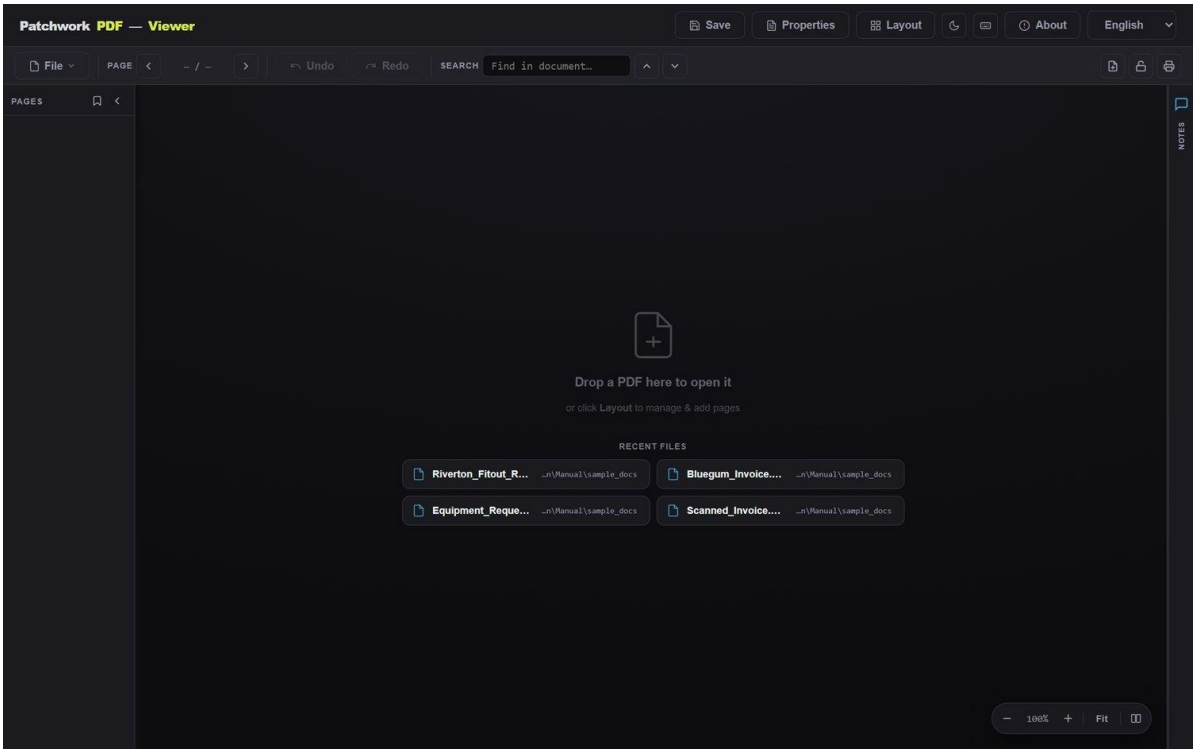
The Viewer is the screen you see when PatchworkPDF starts. With a document open, the page thumbnails are on the left, the pages in the centre, and the collapsible Notes / Tools panel on the right.



The Viewer with two documents open in tabs.

1.1 Opening documents

When nothing is open, the Viewer shows a drop zone and your recent files:



The welcome screen.

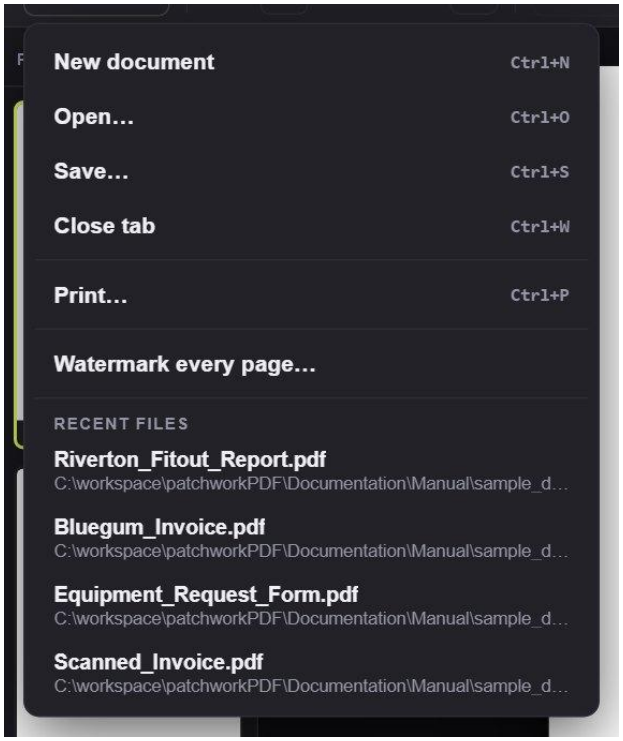
- **Drop zone** — drag one or more files onto the window, or click the drop zone to choose files.
- **Recent files** — click a card to reopen a document you used recently. The same list is in the **File** menu.
- **File → Open…** (Ctrl+O) — at any time, even with other documents open.

Each file opens in its own tab (section 1.3). To combine files into one document, use Layout (chapter 4).

Password-protected documents

If a PDF needs a password to open, you are asked for it before it loads. A document that opens but whose owner has restricted editing is marked **Read-only**: you can read, search, print and copy from it, but the tools that change it are disabled. Click the Read-only badge and enter the owner password to lift the restriction.

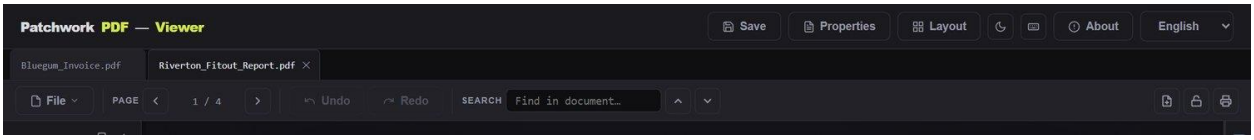
1.2 The File menu



- **New document** (Ctrl+N) — start with a blank page.
- **Open…** (Ctrl+O), **Save…** (Ctrl+S), **Close tab** (Ctrl+W) and **Print…** (Ctrl+P).
- **Watermark every page…** — stamp the current watermark settings onto every page (section 3.5).
- **Recent files** — reopen a recently used document.

1.3 Tabs and windows

Every document you open gets a tab just below the header. Each tab remembers its own page, zoom and scroll position.



- **Switch** — click a tab.
- **Close** — click the ✕ on the tab, or press Ctrl+W. The last remaining tab can't be closed; open another document instead.
- **Pop out** — drag a tab away from the tab bar to open that document in a new window (handy for a second screen). Drag it back onto another PatchworkPDF window to dock it there.

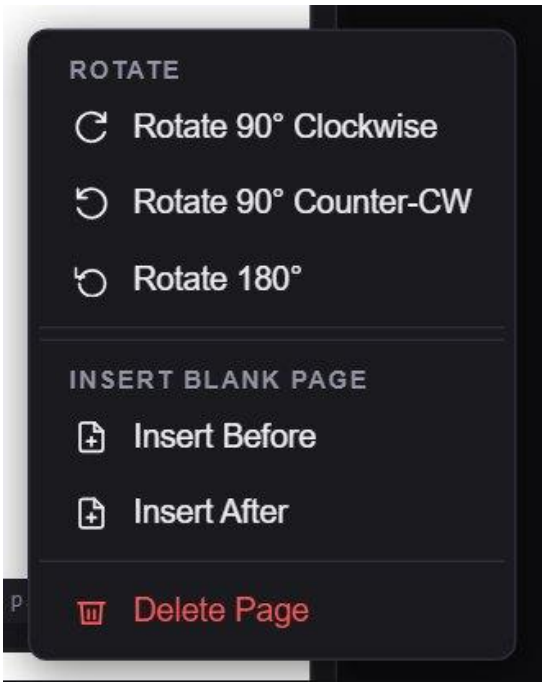
> **NOTE** If a document has unsaved changes, PatchworkPDF asks before closing its tab or the app.

1.4 Pages and bookmarks (left panel)

The left panel shows either page thumbnails or bookmarks. Switch between them with the icons in the panel header.

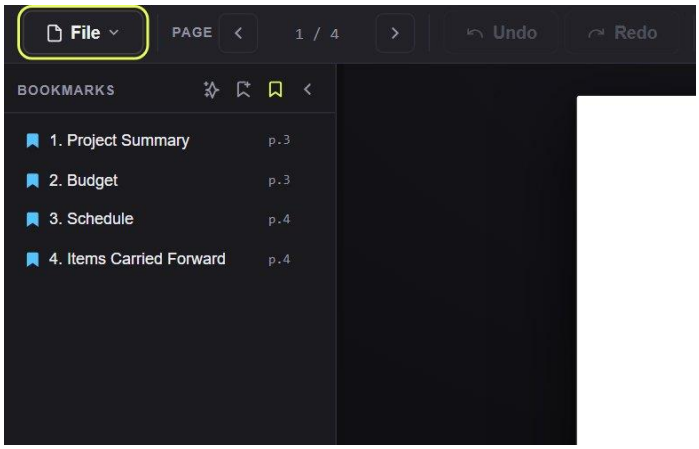
Pages

- Click a thumbnail to go to that page; the current page is outlined.
- While a search is active, pages containing a match show a small blue dot.
- Right-click a thumbnail to **rotate** the page, **insert a blank page** before or after it (you choose the paper size), or **delete** it.



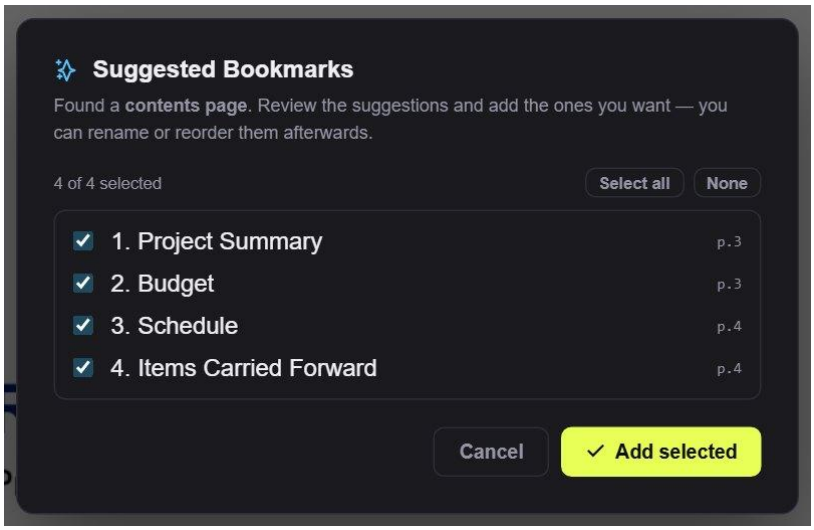
Bookmarks

- **Add** — click the bookmark (+) button to bookmark the current page, or right-click the page and choose **Add bookmark here** to bookmark that exact spot.
- **Go to** — click a bookmark.
- **Manage** — right-click a bookmark to rename it, move it up or down, delete it, delete the selected bookmarks or delete them all.



Automatic bookmarks

A PDF's own bookmark outline is loaded automatically. For a document without one, click the wand button: PatchworkPDF looks for a printed Contents page and reads its entries, or, if there isn't one, detects headings by their text size. Untick any suggestions you don't want and click **Add selected**.



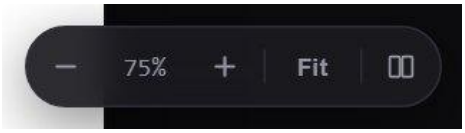
Resizing the panel

- Drag the panel's right edge to make it wider or narrower — the width is remembered.
- Click the arrow in the panel header to collapse it.

1.5 Moving around: pages, zoom and full screen

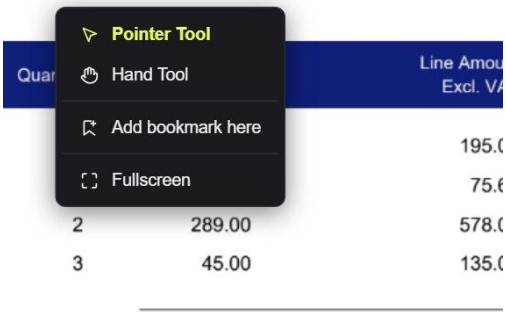
- **Previous / next page** — the arrows in the toolbar, or the Up / Down / Page Up / Page Down keys.
- **Go to a page** — double-click the page counter and type a number.

The zoom controls sit in a floating bar at the bottom-right of the page:



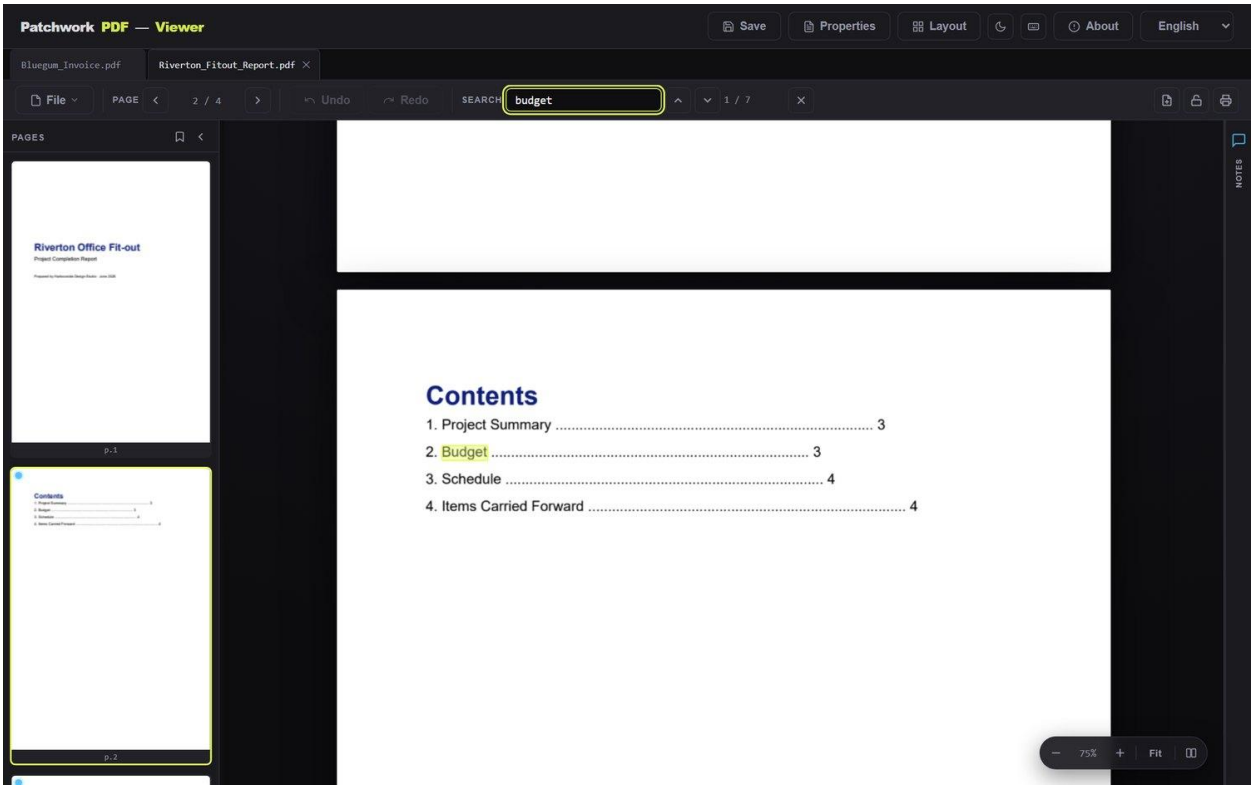
- **– / +** step the zoom (also the − and + keys). Hold **Ctrl** and scroll to zoom around the mouse pointer.
- Click the **percentage** to return to 100%; **Fit** fits the page to the window width.
- The last button shows **two pages side by side**.

Right-click the page for the **Pointer** and **Hand** tools, **Add bookmark here**, and **Fullscreen** (press Esc to leave full screen).



1.6 Search

Type in **Find in document…** (Ctrl+F) to highlight every match as you type. Press **Enter** / **Shift+Enter** (or the arrows) for the next and previous match; the counter shows where you are. Press **Esc** or ✕ to clear.

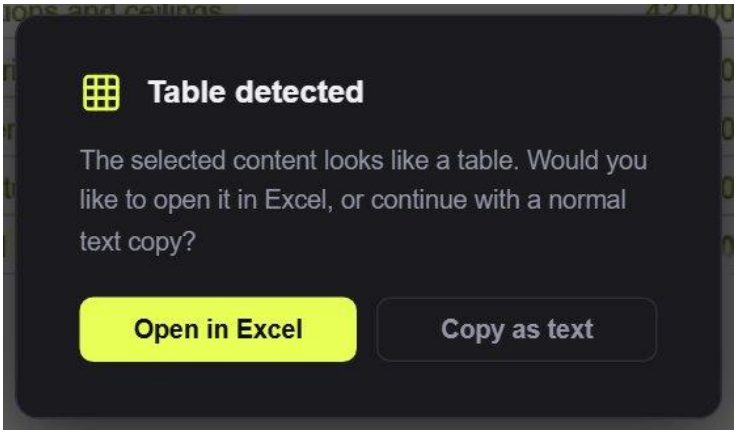


> **TIP** Search uses the document's text. Scanned pages are read with OCR the first time you search them (this needs Tesseract).

1.7 Selecting and copying text

With the **Pointer** tool (right-click the page to choose it), drag a box over some text. The text inside the box is copied to the clipboard straight away. On a scanned page the text is read with OCR first.

If the selection looks like a table, PatchworkPDF offers to open it in **Excel** as a real spreadsheet, or to copy it as plain text:



Use the **Hand** tool to drag the page around without selecting anything.

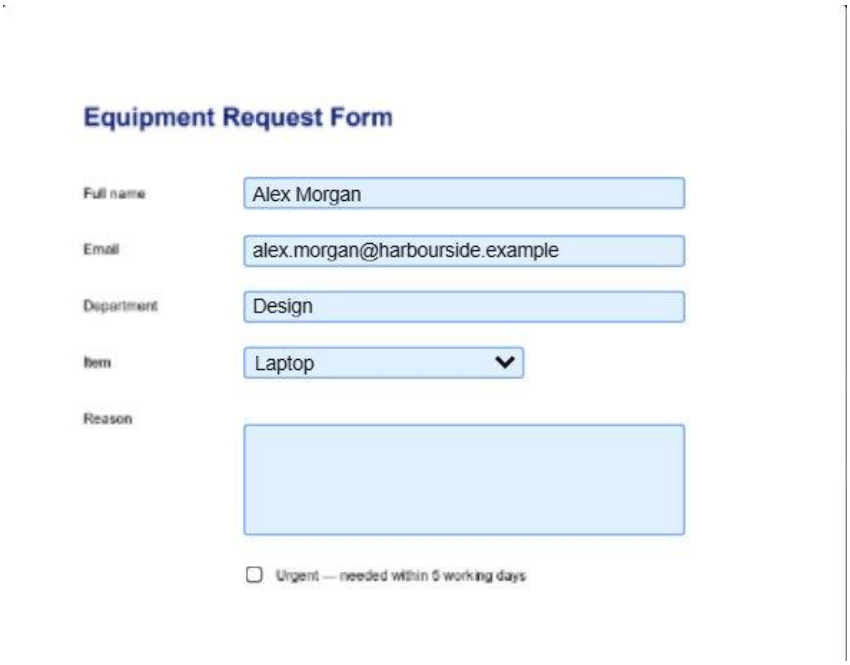
1.8 Links

Web and email links in a PDF are clickable. Hover over one to see where it goes, and click to open it in your web browser. Only web (http, https) and email links are opened.



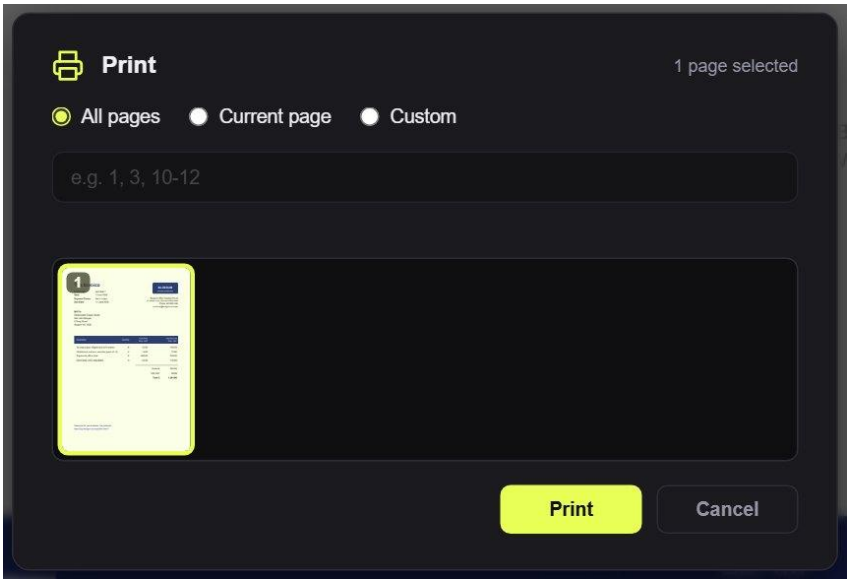
1.9 Filling in forms

If a PDF has form fields, you can fill them in directly: click a field and type, tick check boxes, and choose from drop-down lists. Your entries are saved into the PDF when you save. To add, move or resize fields yourself, use the **Field** tool (section 3.8).



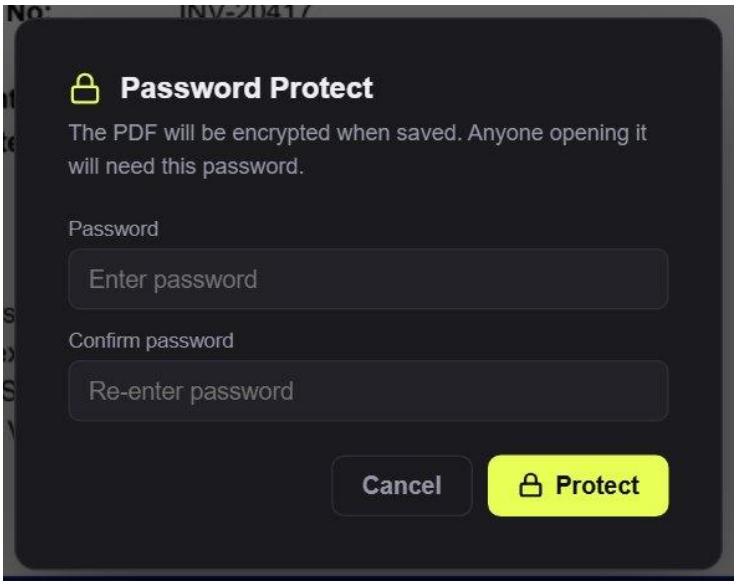
1.10 Printing

Click the printer button or press **Ctrl+P**. Choose **All pages**, the **Current page**, or a **Custom** range such as 1, 3, 10-12, then click **Print** to open your system's print dialog with just those pages.

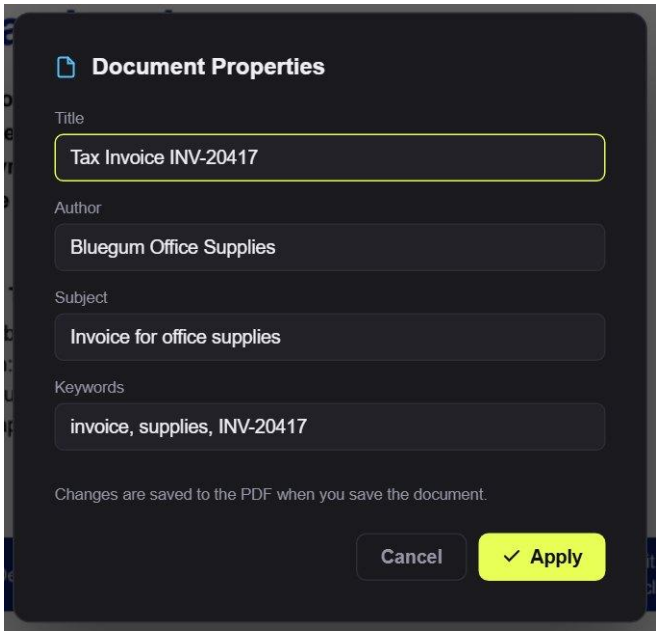


1.11 Saving, passwords and document properties

- **Save** (Ctrl+S, or the Save button) writes the whole document — annotations, edits and form entries included.
- **Password protect** (the lock button in the toolbar) encrypts the PDF when you save; anyone opening it will need the password. Open the same dialog again to change or remove the password.



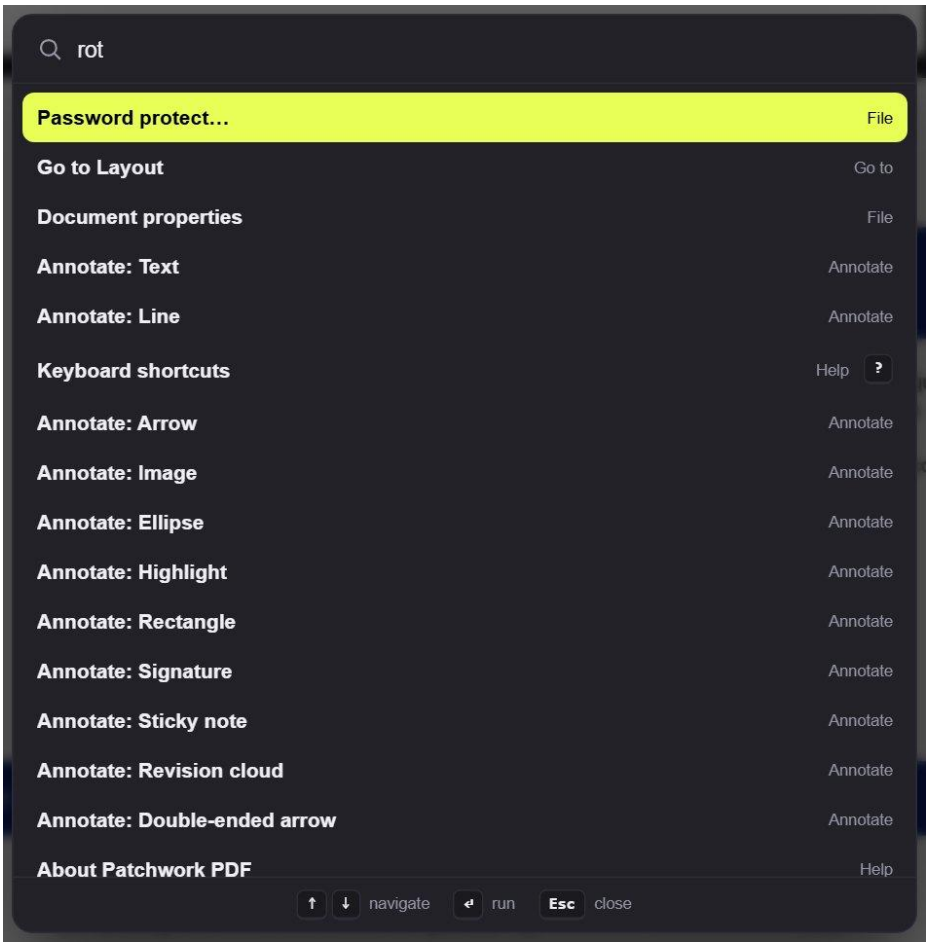
- **Properties** shows and edits the document's title, author, subject and keywords. They are written into the PDF when you save.



1.12 Header buttons, command palette and settings

- **Save**, **Properties** and **Layout** (chapter 4).
- **Theme** — switch between the dark and light appearance.
- **Keyboard shortcuts** — the full list (also press **?**). See chapter 5.
- **About** — the version, and buttons for this **Manual**, the **Changelog**, **What's New**, **Check for Updates**, the **License** and **Shortcuts**.
- **Language** — English, Español, Français, Deutsch or Italiano.

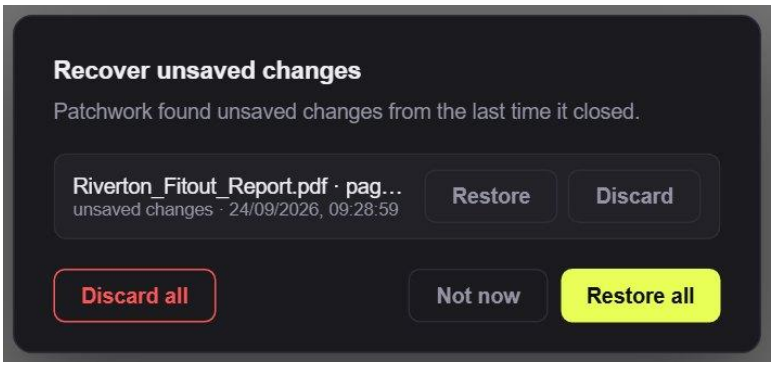
Press **Ctrl+K** for the **command palette**: type part of a command's name and press Enter to run it — a quick way to reach anything without hunting through menus.





1.13 Unsaved-work recovery and updates

PatchworkPDF keeps a recovery copy of documents with unsaved changes. If it closes unexpectedly, the next time it starts it offers to restore them. **Restore** reopens the work; **Discard** throws it away; **Not now** leaves it for next time.



PatchworkPDF also checks SourceForge for a newer version now and then and tells you when one is available, with its release notes and a download button. You can turn the reminder off in that window, and check by hand from **About → Check for Updates**.

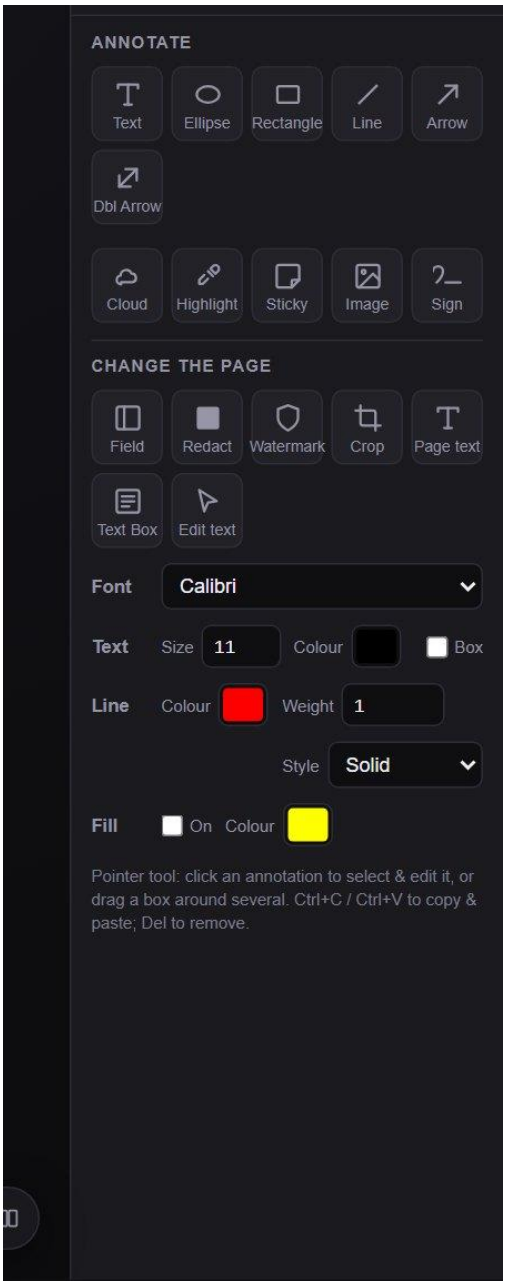
2. Annotating

Annotations are notes, shapes, highlights and signatures that sit on top of the page. They are standard PDF annotations, so they also show in other PDF readers such as Adobe Acrobat, and they can be selected, edited, moved and deleted later.

2.1 The right-hand panel

The panel on the right edge starts folded away as a **Notes** tab; the number shows how many notes and annotations the document has. Click the tab to open the panel. It has two views, chosen at the top:

- **Tools** — the annotation tools (**Annotate**) and the page-changing tools (**Change the page**, chapter 3), with their settings below.
- **Annotations** — a list of every note and annotation in the document (section 2.5).



The Tools view.

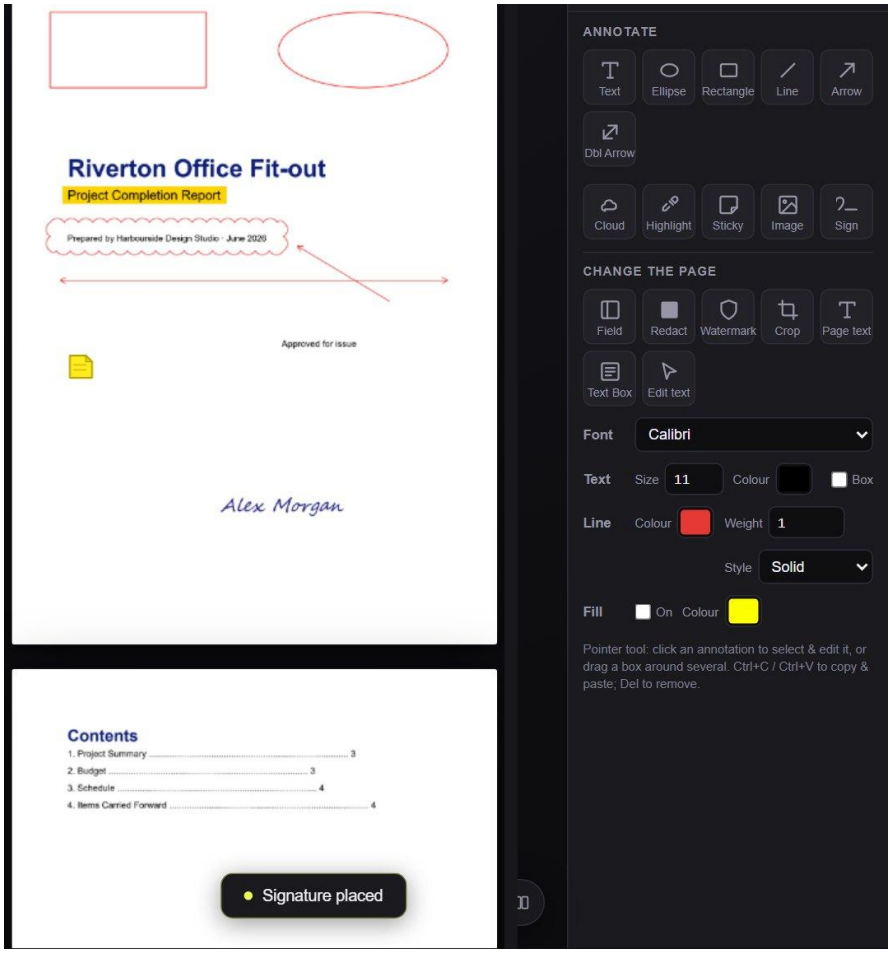
2.2 Annotation tools

Click a tool to arm it, then draw on the page. While you are drawing, **Esc** cancels the shape and **Enter** finishes it. Click the tool again, or press **Esc** when you are not drawing, to put it away. Switching to another tab also puts it away.

Tool	How to use it
Text	Drag a box and type. Tick **Box** to give it a border.
Ellipse, **Rectangle**	Drag to draw. Turn **Fill** on for a filled shape.

Tool	How to use it
Line, **Arrow**, **Dbl Arrow**	Drag from start to end. The double arrow is handy for dimensions.
Cloud	Drag to draw a revision cloud round an area.
Highlight	Drag over text to highlight it.
Sticky	Type the note (and your name), then click the page to place it.
Image	Choose a picture file, then drag to place and size it.
Sign	Type your name, pick a handwriting style, size and colour, then click the page.

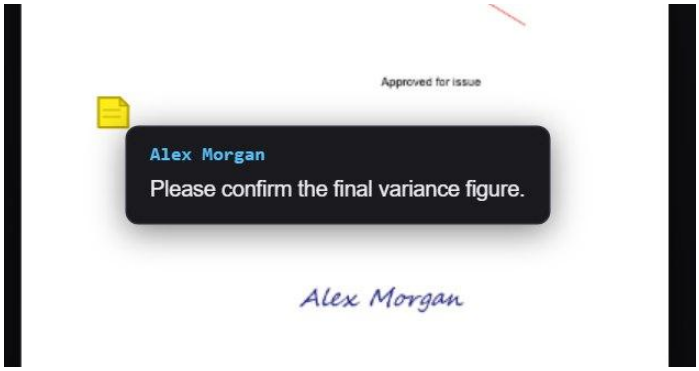
Style controls under the tools set the **font**, **text size and colour**, **line colour, weight and style** (solid, dashed or dotted) and **fill**. Changing a control also restyles the annotation you are currently drawing or have selected.



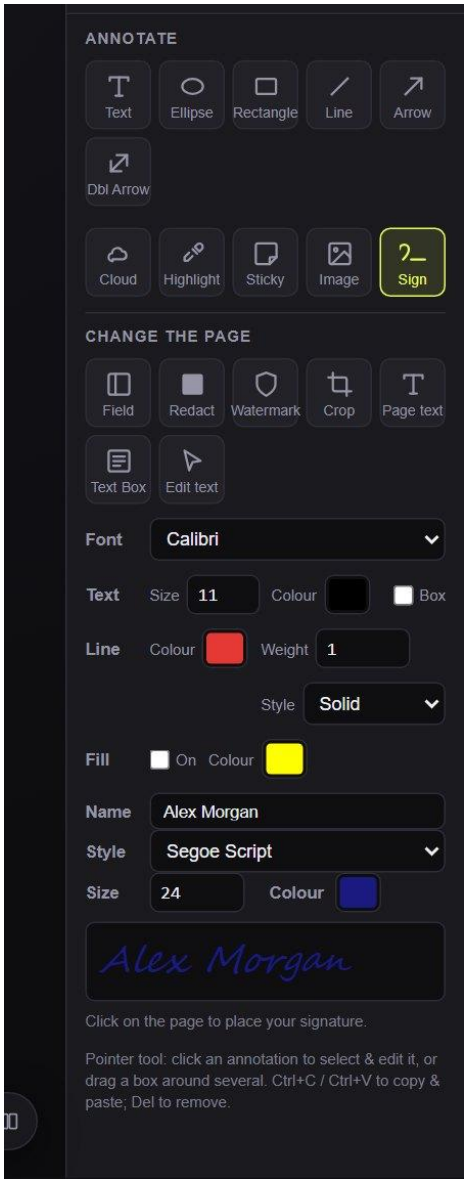
A page with a rectangle, ellipse, highlight, revision cloud, arrows, a text note, a sticky note and a signature.

2.3 Sticky notes and signatures

Hover over a sticky note to read it, with the author's name:

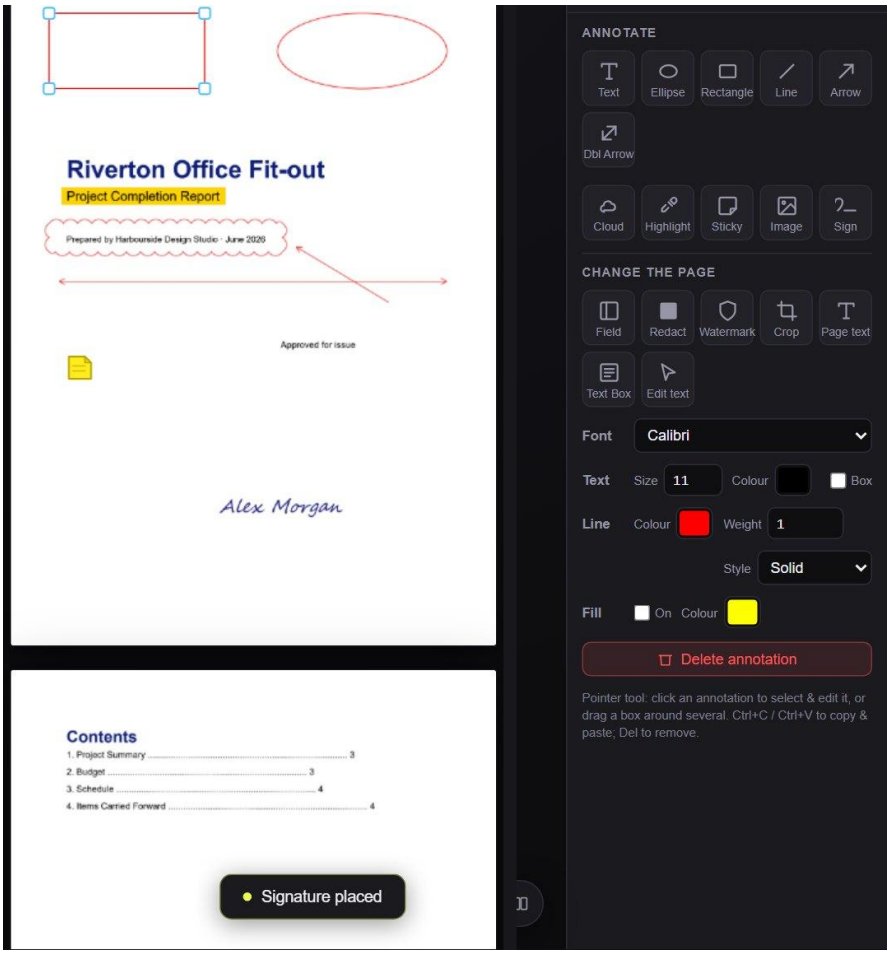


The **Sign** tool previews your signature in the panel before you place it:



2.4 Selecting, changing and removing annotations

- With no tool armed, click an annotation to select it. Drag it to move it, or drag its handles to resize it, and use the style controls to change it.
- Click a sticky note to edit its text and author, or to delete it.
- Press **Delete** (or click **Delete annotation** in the panel) to remove it.
- Drag a box round several annotations to select them together.
- **Ctrl+C / Ctrl+V** copies and pastes annotations — onto another page too.
- **Ctrl+V** with a picture on the clipboard pastes it onto the page as an image.



A selected rectangle, with its handles and the Delete annotation button.

2.5 The Annotations list and Add Note

Choose **Annotations** at the top of the panel to see every note and annotation in the document. Click one to jump to it. To add a note, type in the box at the bottom and click **Add Note**, then drag on the page to place it.



2.6 Undo and redo

Undo (Ctrl+Z) and **Redo** (Ctrl+Y or Ctrl+Shift+Z) are in the toolbar and cover annotations and every page change in chapter 3. They work until you save or close the document.

3. Changing the Page

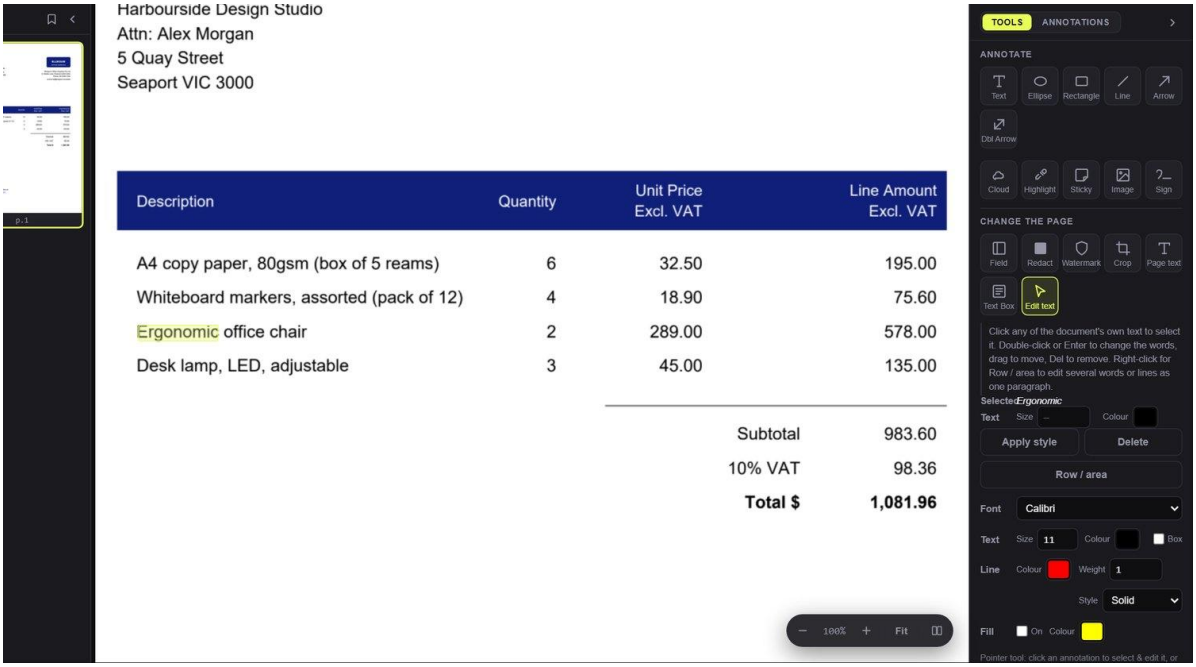
The tools under **Change the page** in the Tools panel change the page's own content rather than adding something on top of it. They replace the separate Editor screen of earlier versions.

> **IMPORTANT** Every change is applied to the page straight away — there is no Apply button. **Ctrl+Z** undoes a change until you save. Once saved, the change is part of the document, so keep a copy of the original if you might need it.

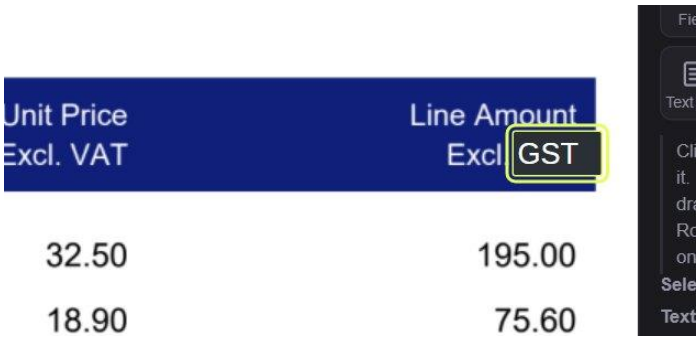
3.1 Edit text

Changes, moves or deletes the words already on the page.

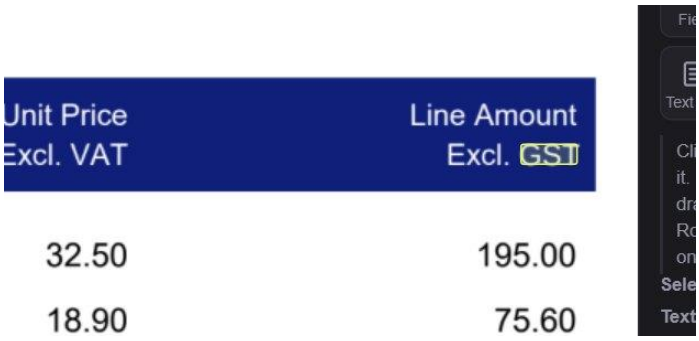
1. Open the Tools panel and click **Edit text**.
2. Click a word to select it — it turns yellow. The panel shows what is selected.
3. **Double-click** (or press Enter) to change the words. Type the replacement and press **Enter**, or click elsewhere. **Esc** cancels.



Edit text armed, with "Ergonomic" selected.



Typing the replacement. The edit box uses the text's own colour — here white — on a background you can read it against.



The result, in place in the header.

Other things you can do with a selected word:

- **Move** it — drag it.
- **Delete** it — press Delete, or click **Delete** in the panel.
- **Restyle** it — set the size and colour in the panel and click **Apply style**.

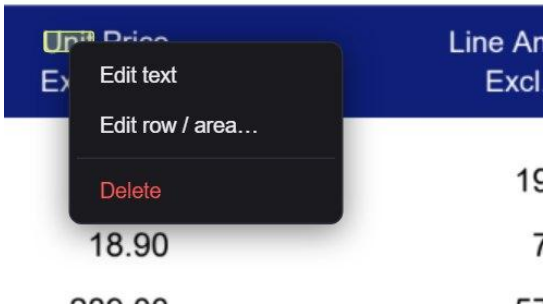
Edit text works on one page at a time — the page you are viewing. When two pages are on screen, click the text you want on the other page and Edit text moves to that page and selects it.

A PDF doesn't reflow, so a longer replacement can't push the next word along. PatchworkPDF squeezes the new text slightly to fit the space it has, and tells you if it had to make it smaller or if it simply won't fit.

3.2 Editing several words or lines (Row / area)

To change a phrase, a whole line, or a paragraph spanning several lines, edit it as one block:

1. With **Edit text** armed, right-click a word and choose **Edit row / area…** (or select a word and click **Row / area** in the panel).



2. A box appears round the words on that line. Drag the box, or its handles, to take in more words or lines or to leave some out. The words it will take are tinted, and the text is previewed above it.



3. Press **Enter** or double-click the box, and edit the text as a paragraph. **Enter** applies it; **Shift+Enter** starts a new line; **Esc** cancels.



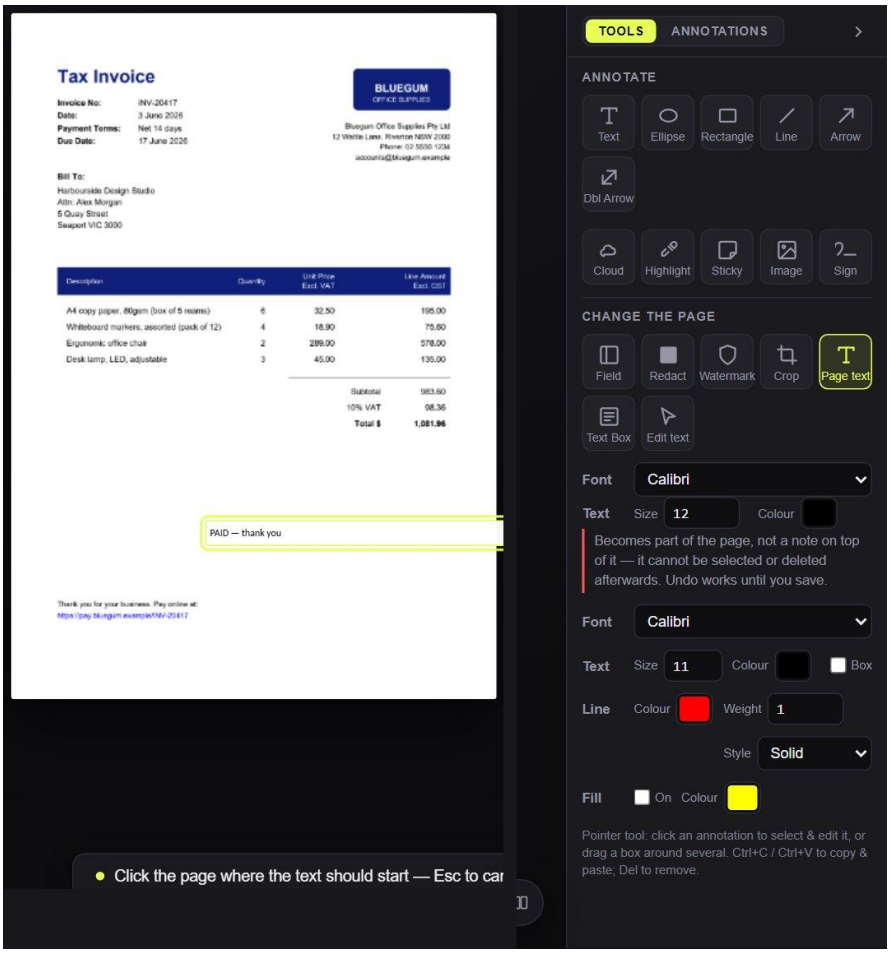
The new text keeps the original's font, size, colour, line spacing and alignment (left, right or centred), and wraps to the width of the area.

3.3 Page text and Text Box

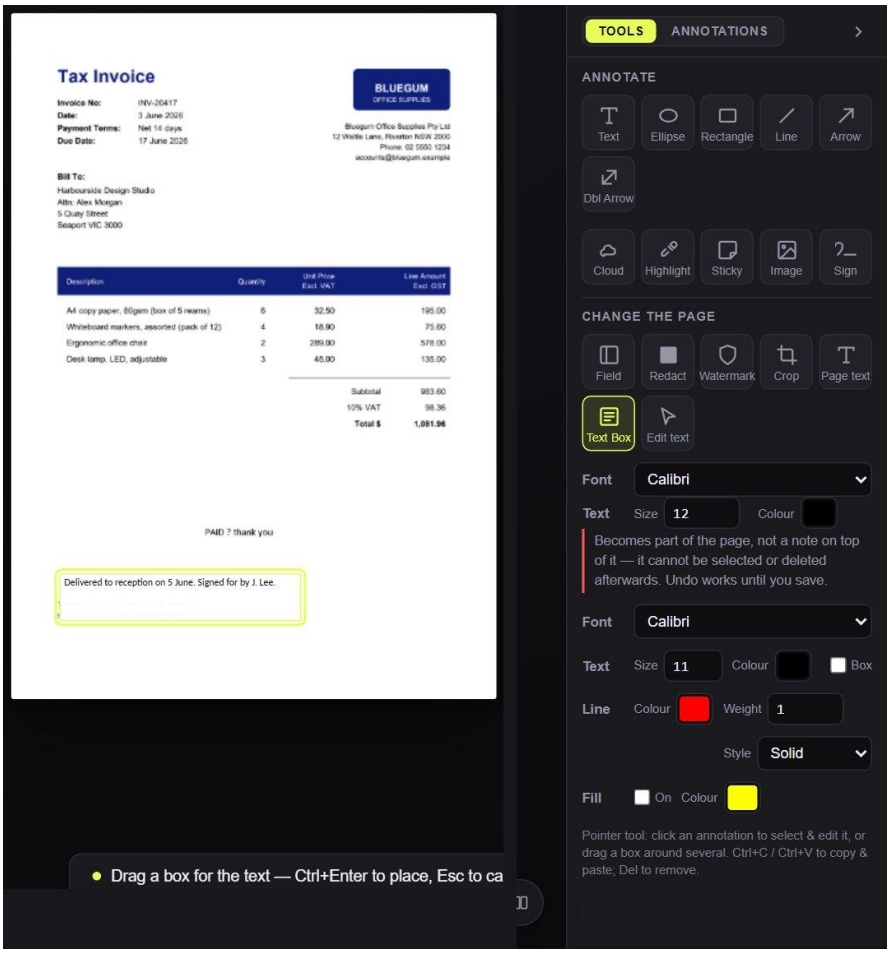
Adds new text into the page. Unlike the **Text** annotation (section 2.2), this becomes part of the page content: afterwards it can't be selected or deleted as an object — use Undo, or Edit text, to change it.

- **Page text** — click where the text should start, type one line and press Enter.
- **Text Box** — drag a box, type (the text wraps to the box) and press **Ctrl+Enter** to place it.

Set the font, size and colour in the panel first. Clicking away also places the text; Esc discards it.



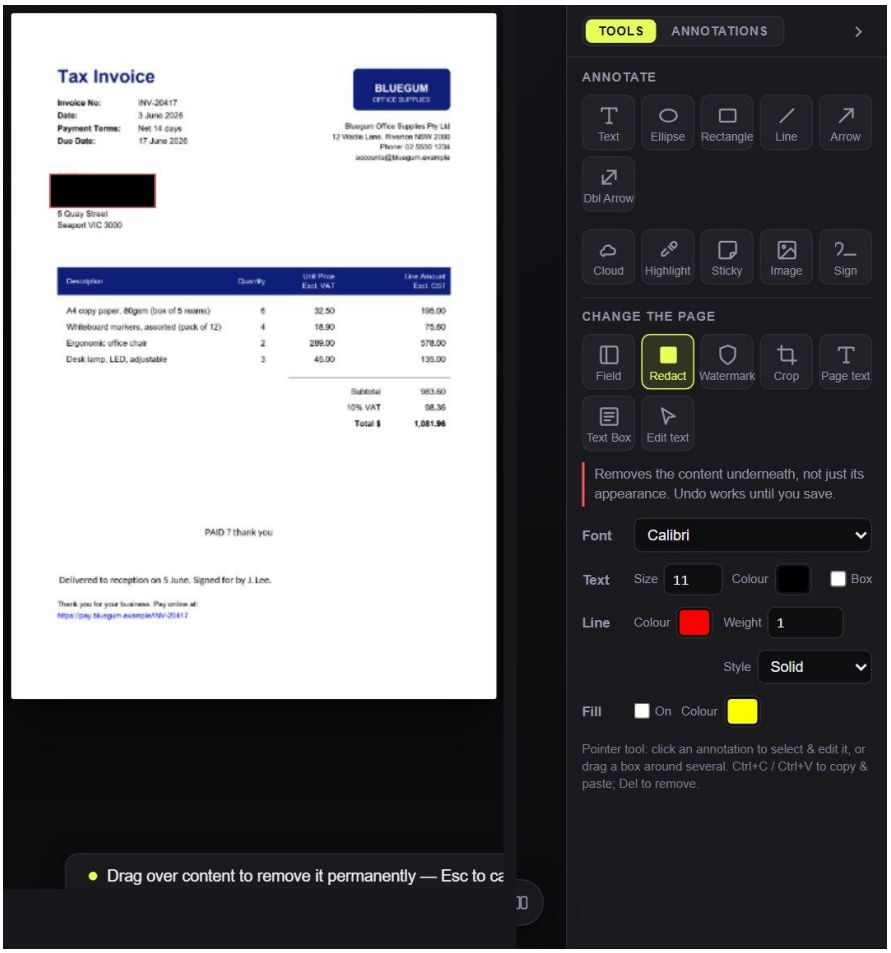
Page text being typed onto the invoice.



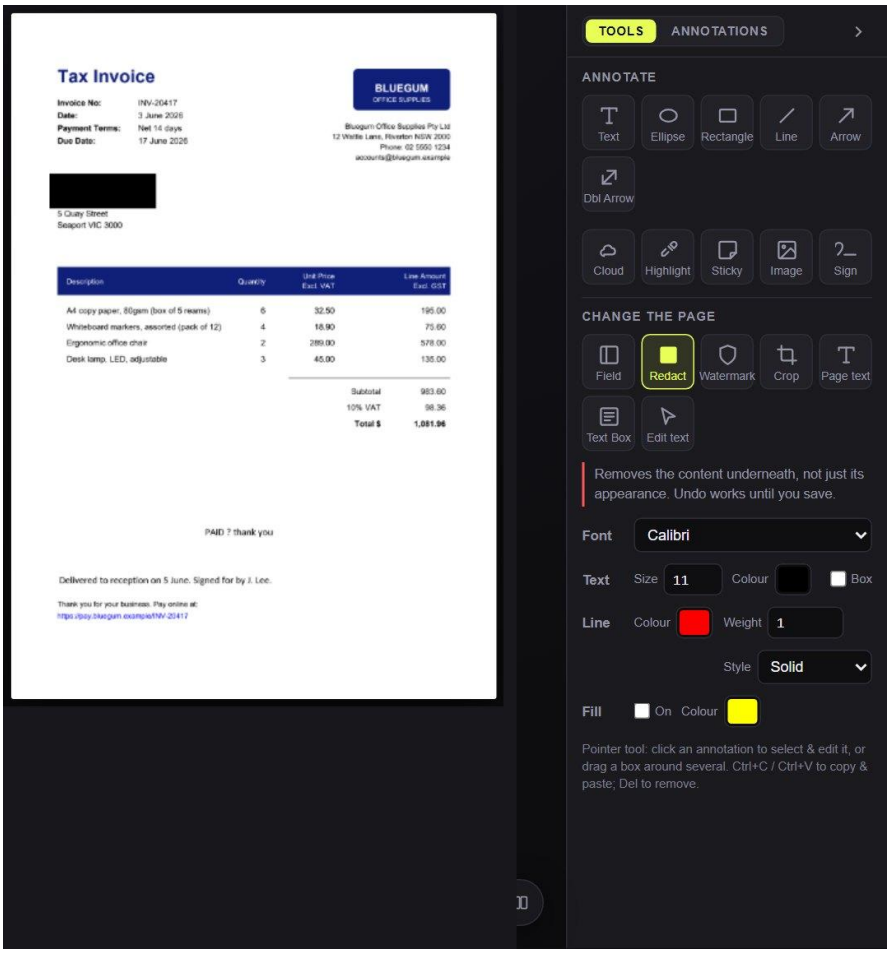
A Text Box being typed.

3.4 Redact

Removes content permanently — not just its appearance. Click **Redact** and drag over the area to remove. The text underneath is deleted from the page and any picture under the box is blanked, then the area is covered in black.



Dragging a redaction over the “Bill To” address.

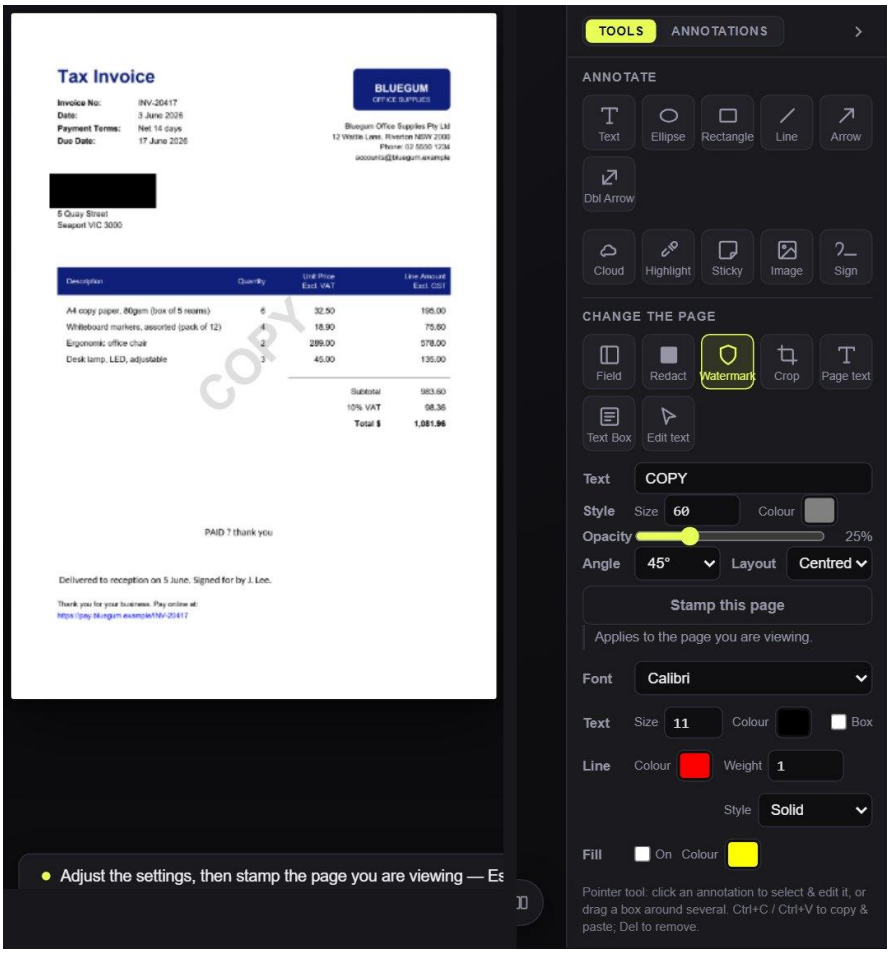


After the redaction.

> **IMPORTANT** Undo works until you save. After you save, redacted content is gone from the file for good — keep an unredacted copy if you may need it.

3.5 Watermark

Stamps text across the page. Set the **text**, **size**, **colour**, **opacity**, **angle** and **layout** (Centred, or Tiled across the page); a live preview shows on the page you are viewing. Click **Stamp this page** to apply it.

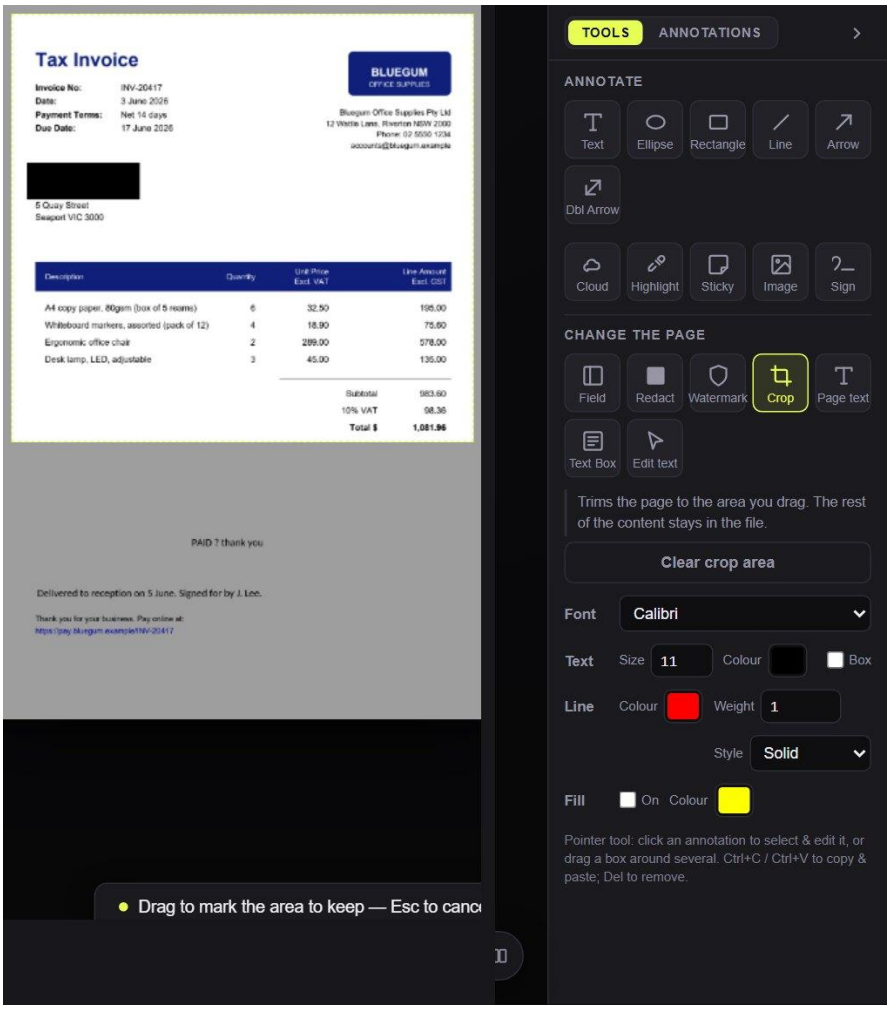


To watermark every page, choose **File → Watermark every page…**. This uses the settings in the Watermark panel.

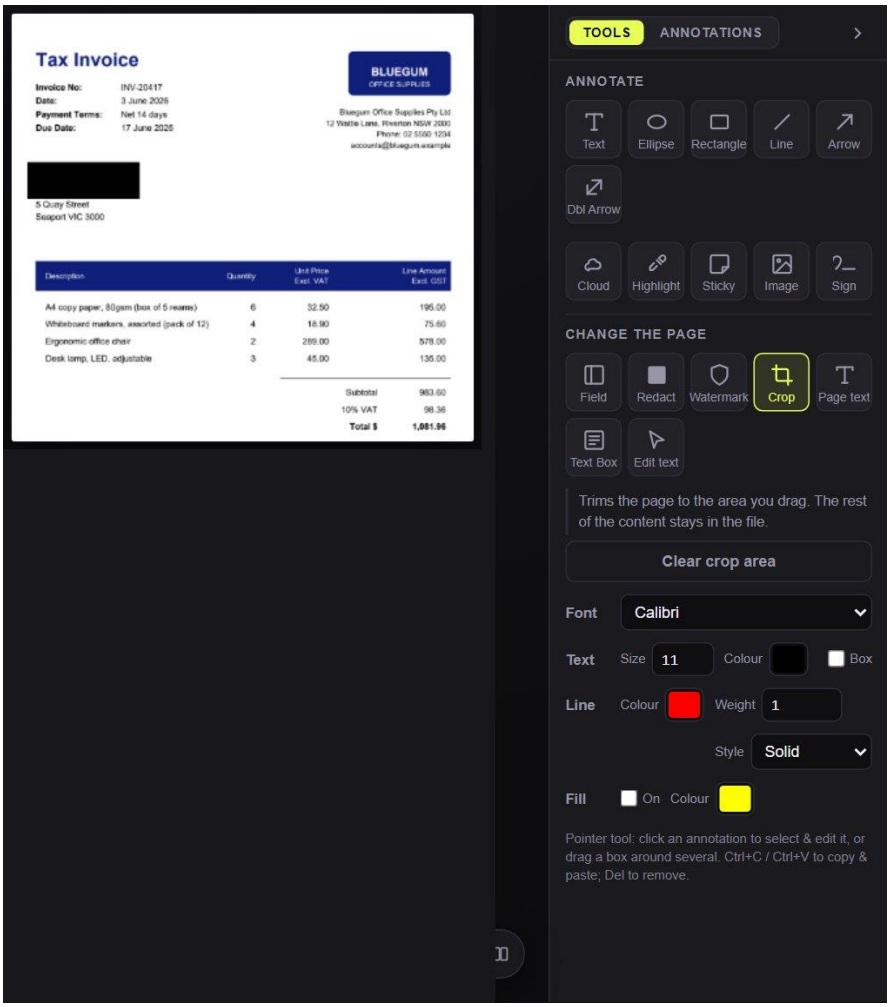
> **NOTE** Watermarking every page can't be undone page by page, so PatchworkPDF asks first, and it clears the undo history.

3.6 Crop

Trims the page to the area you drag; the rest of the page is hidden. Click **Crop** and drag the area to keep. **Clear crop area** in the panel restores the full page, and Undo works too.



Dragging the area to keep.



The cropped page.

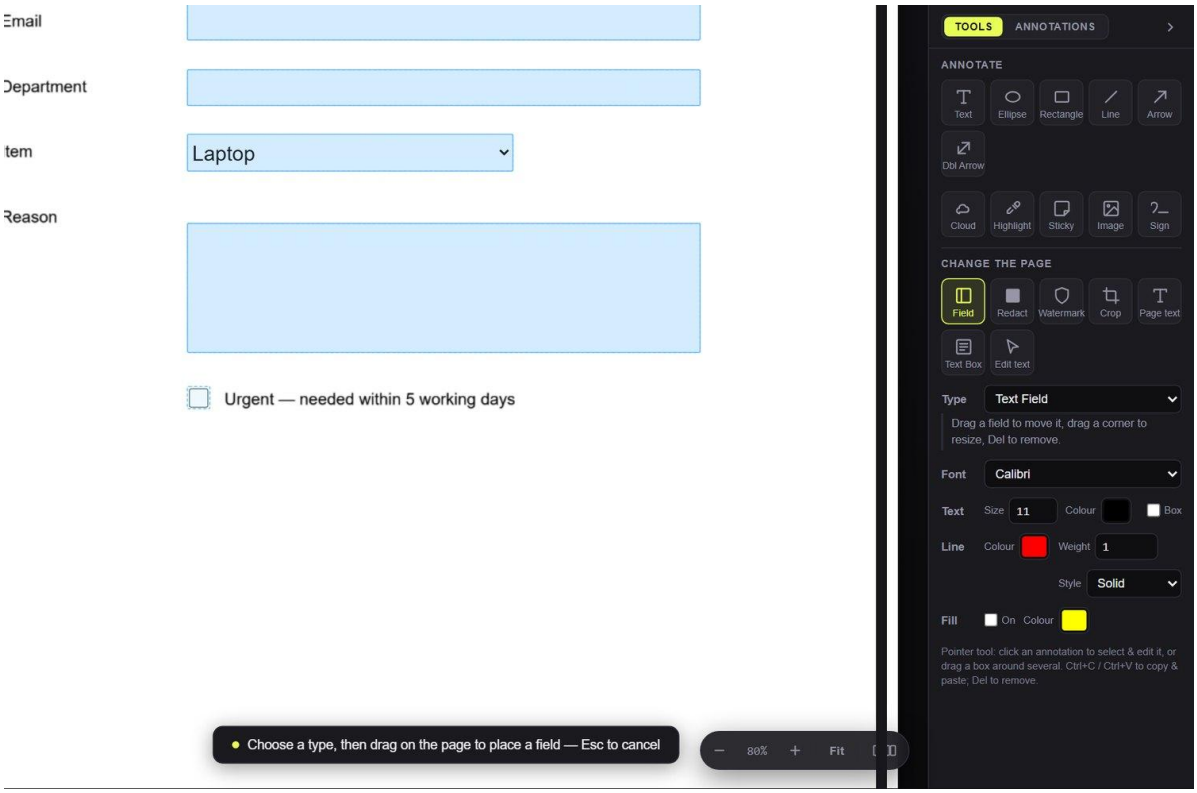
3.7 Undo for page changes

Every page change is a single step in the toolbar's **Undo** and **Redo** (Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y), shared with annotations.

3.8 Form fields (the Field tool)

Adds, moves and resizes form fields. Choose a **Type** — Text Field, Multiline Text, Checkbox, Radio Button, Dropdown or List Box — then drag on the page to place it.

While the Field tool is armed, fields stop being fillable so they can be edited: drag a field to move it, drag a corner to resize it, and press **Delete** to remove it. Put the tool away to fill the form in again.

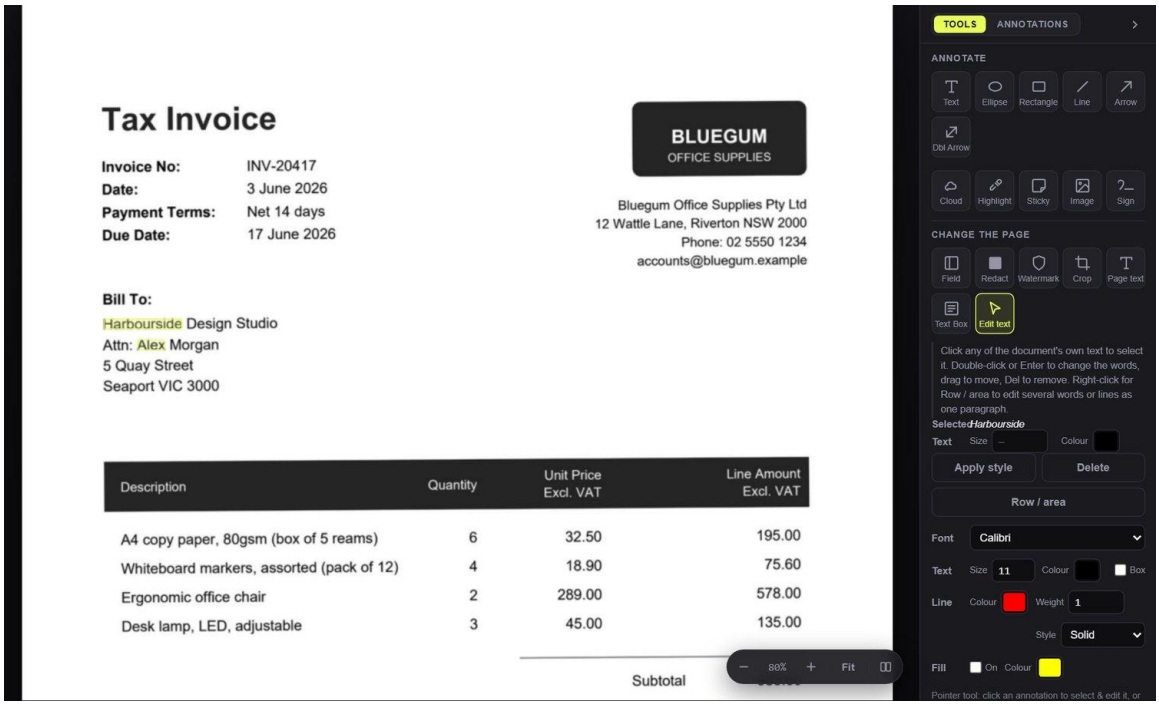


3.9 Scanned documents and OCR

PDFs come in two kinds, and PatchworkPDF treats them differently.

Digital PDFs are created by a computer — saved from Word, for example. Their text is real text, so PatchworkPDF can read, search and edit it directly and accurately.

Scanned PDFs are pictures of paper. To work with their text, PatchworkPDF first reads it with OCR (Tesseract). When you arm Edit text on a scanned page, it is read automatically; this takes a few seconds.



Edit text on a scanned invoice: the OCR-read word “Harbourside” is selected.

What to expect when you edit a scanned page:

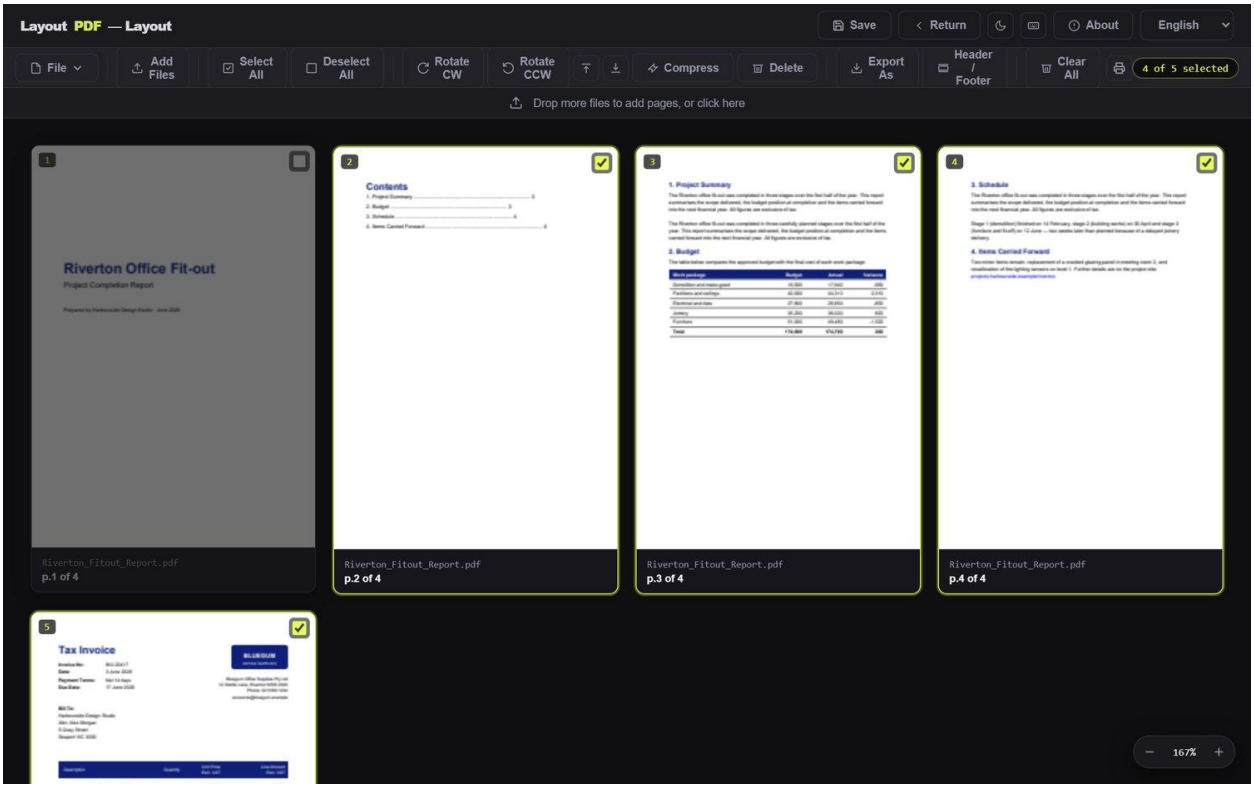
- **OCR needs Tesseract.** Without it the page’s text can’t be edited, though you can still annotate, redact, watermark and add text.
- **OCR is a best guess.** Clean, straight scans read well. Faint, skewed, low-resolution or unusual text — handwriting, stylised lettering, text inside boxes — may be misread or missed.
- **Positions are approximate**, so replacement text may need nudging into place.
- **Editing works by cover and replace.** The original is covered with a patch in the background colour and the new text is written on top. On plain backgrounds this is invisible; on textured or shaded backgrounds the patch can show.
- **Saved scans stay editable.** A scanned page you have edited and saved is recognised when you reopen it, and its scanned text is read again.

NOTE In short: PatchworkPDF is excellent at adding to scanned documents — redacting, highlighting, stamping, signing, annotating and filling — and can edit their text, with the accuracy of the OCR.

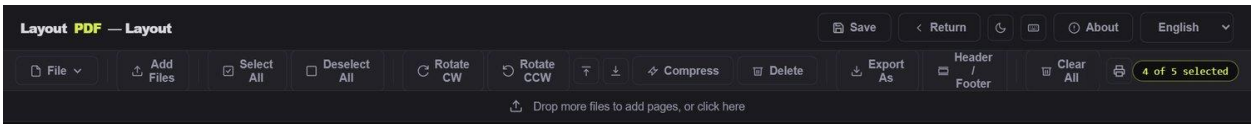
NOTE A page that is both cropped and rotated can’t be edited with the page tools; PatchworkPDF says so rather than risk putting a change in the wrong place. Annotations still work there.

4. The Layout Screen

Layout is where you arrange the document as a whole. Open it with the **Layout** button in the Viewer, and return with **Return**.



Layout with a four-page report and an invoice combined. The report's cover page is unticked.



The Layout toolbar.

4.1 Adding and combining files

- Drop files onto the Layout screen, or onto the strip under the toolbar.
- Click **Add Files** in the toolbar.

Each file's pages are added to the end, so you can build one PDF from many sources — Word, Excel and PDF together.

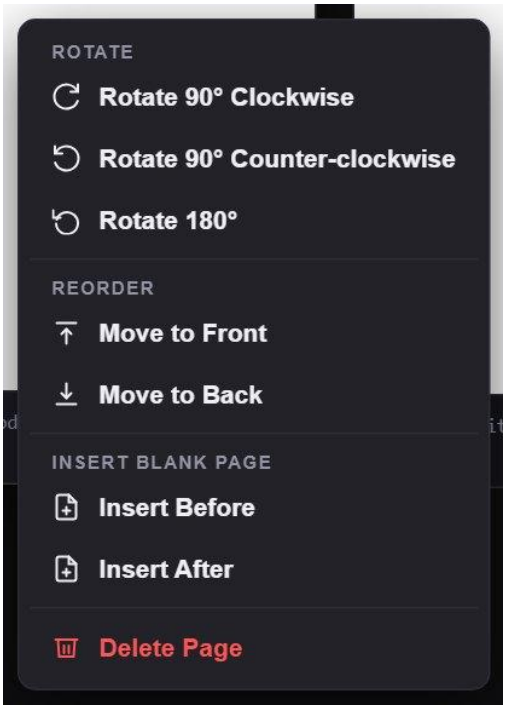
4.2 Choosing pages

Every page card has a tick box, and all pages start ticked. **Save**, **Rotate**, **Delete**, **Compress** and **Move to Front / Back** act on the ticked pages; the badge shows how many are ticked. **Select All** and **Deselect All** tick or untick everything.

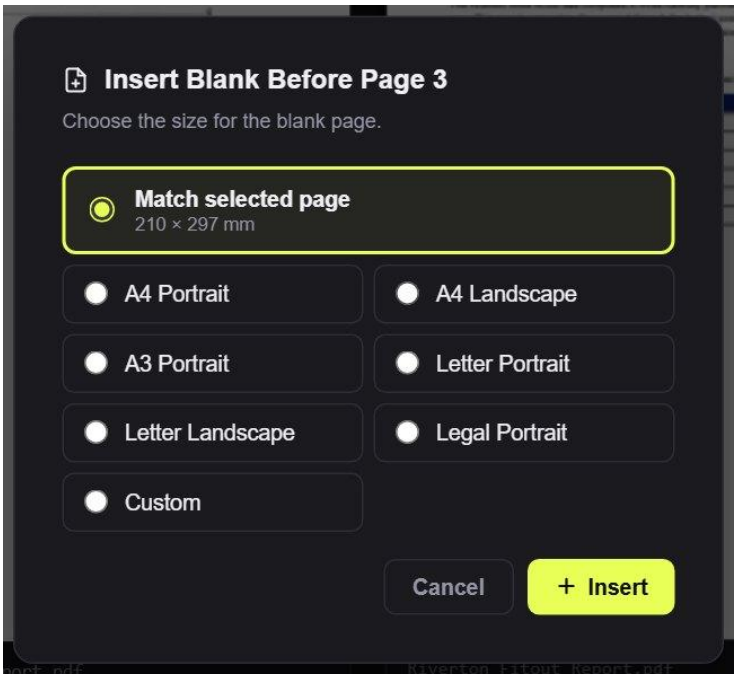
TIP Saving with only some pages ticked writes just those pages to a new PDF — a quick way to extract pages.

4.3 Arranging pages

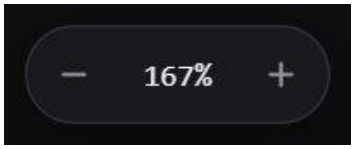
- **Reorder** — drag a card to a new position.
- **Rotate CW / CCW**, **Move to Front / Back** and **Delete** — act on the ticked pages.
- **Right-click a card** to rotate, reorder, insert a blank page before or after it, or delete just that page.



Inserting a blank page asks for its size — matching the selected page, a standard paper size, or a custom size:



- **Clear All** removes every page from Layout.
- The zoom control at the bottom-right changes the size of the page cards.

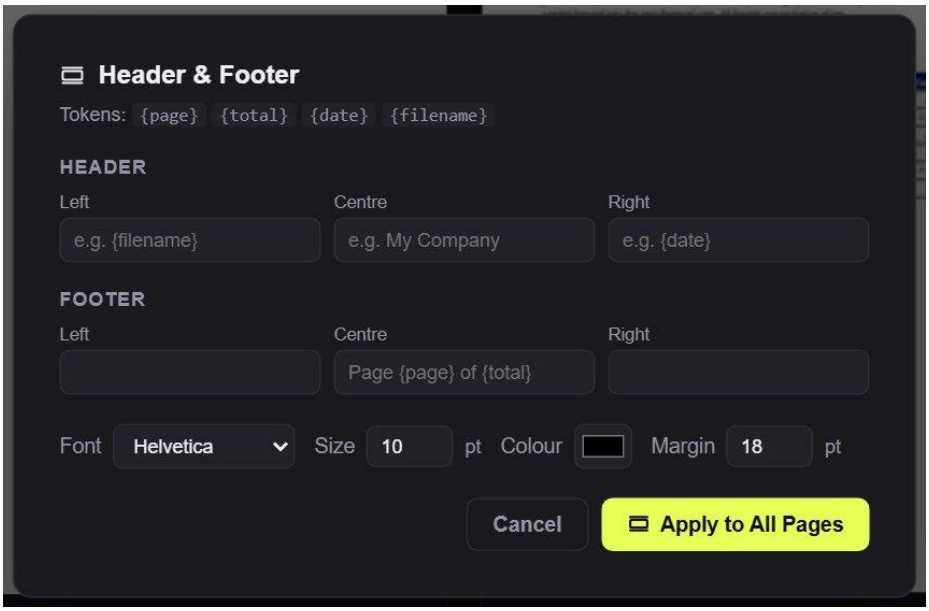


4.4 Header and footer

Click **Header / Footer** to add text to the top and bottom of every page, each with Left, Centre and Right zones. These tokens are filled in for you:

- **{page}** — the page number
- **{total}** — the number of pages
- **{date}** — today's date
- **{filename}** — the source file name

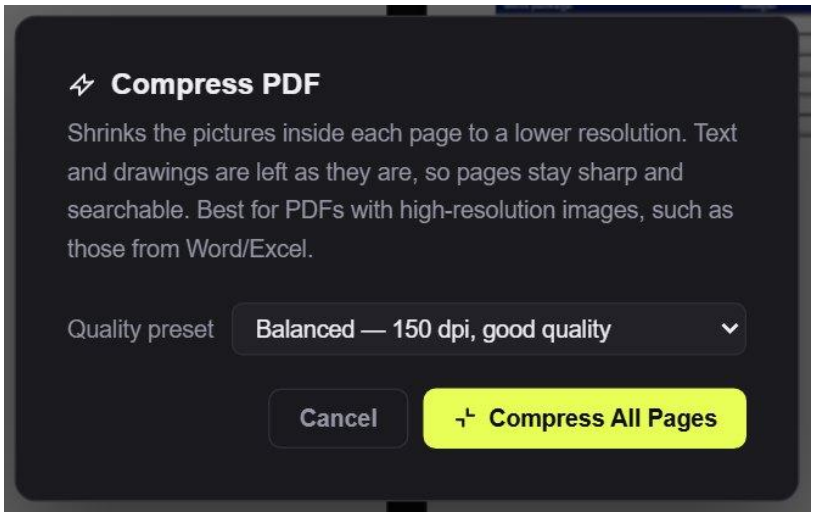
Set the font, size, colour and margin, then click **Apply to All Pages**.



TIP Mix text and tokens, for example “Confidential — {filename}” or “Page {page} of {total}”.

4.5 Compress

Shrinks the pictures inside the ticked pages to a lower resolution, which greatly reduces the size of PDFs with large images — typical of files converted from Word or Excel. Text and drawings are left alone, so pages stay sharp and searchable. Choose **Screen** (96 dpi, smallest), **Balanced** (150 dpi, the default), **Print** (200 dpi) or **Custom** (your own dpi and JPEG quality).

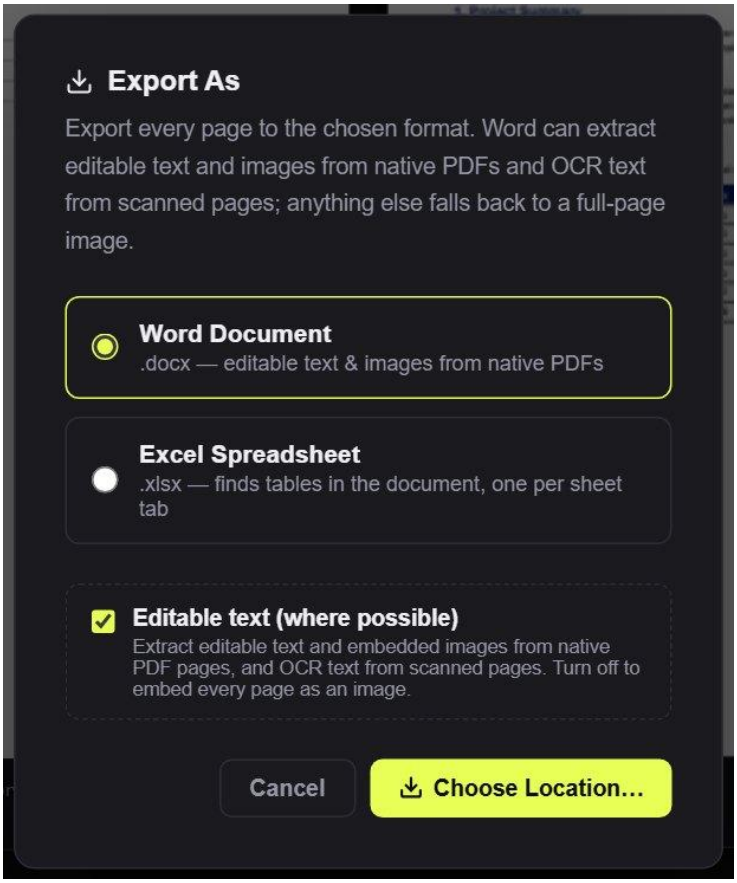


IMPORTANT Compression can’t be undone, and on a scanned page the scan itself is the picture being shrunk, so its text gets softer. Use the Print preset or higher for scans, and save an uncompressed copy first if you may need the original quality.

4.6 Export As

Converts the document to Word or Excel:

- **Word Document (.docx)** — with **Editable text** ticked, the text and pictures of digital PDFs become editable Word content, and scanned pages are read with OCR. Anything else, or every page with the option off, becomes a full-page picture.
- **Excel Spreadsheet (.xlsx)** — finds the tables in the document and puts each on its own sheet.



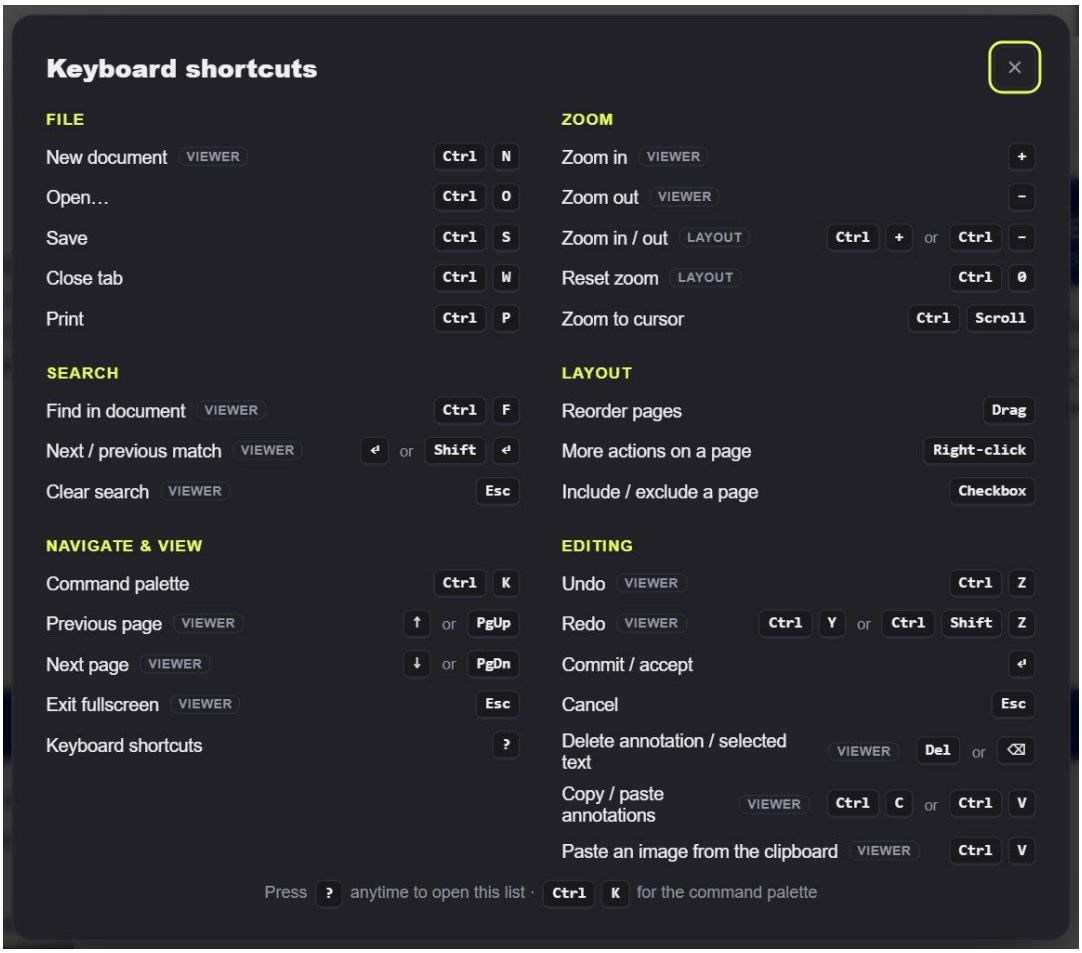
4.7 Saving and printing from Layout

Save writes the ticked pages as a PDF, and the printer button prints the document. Click **Return** to go back to the Viewer, which shows your rearranged document.

5. Keyboard Shortcuts

Press **?** at any time to see this list in the app. On a Mac, use Cmd in place of Ctrl.

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+N	New document
Ctrl+O	Open
Ctrl+S	Save
Ctrl+W	Close tab
Ctrl+P	Print
Ctrl+F	Find in document
Enter / Shift+Enter	Next / previous search match
Esc	Clear search, cancel, or leave full screen
Ctrl+K	Command palette
?	Keyboard shortcuts
Up / Page Up	Previous page
Down / Page Down	Next page
+ / −	Zoom in / out (Viewer)
Ctrl + mouse wheel	Zoom around the pointer
Ctrl++ / Ctrl+− / Ctrl+0	Zoom in / out / reset page size (Layout)
Ctrl+Z	Undo
Ctrl+Y or Ctrl+Shift+Z	Redo
Enter	Commit an edit; open Edit text on the selected word
Delete / Backspace	Delete the selected annotation, word or form field
Ctrl+C / Ctrl+V	Copy / paste annotations; paste a picture from the clipboard
Ctrl+Enter	Place a Text Box



The in-app shortcuts list (press ?).

Troubleshooting

What you see	What to do
Text on a scanned page can't be selected, searched or edited	Install Tesseract (see Installing OCR) and try again.
"Text too long — it overlaps the next word"	The replacement is longer than the space available. Shorten it, or use Row / area to edit the whole line.
A page tool says the page can't be edited	The page is both cropped and rotated. Clear the crop or the rotation first.
The tools are greyed out and the document shows Read-only	The document's owner has restricted editing. Click the Read-only badge and enter the owner password.
Word or Excel files won't open	Install Microsoft Office or LibreOffice, or save the file as PDF from its own application first.
"Recover unsaved changes" at start-up	PatchworkPDF closed with unsaved work. Restore it, or Discard it if you don't need it.